

K-Beauty Assortment Advisory

Opening range & basket architecture for a Gen Z Asian-beauty retail chain

Prepared: 12 Aug 2026 · **Evidence:** Shopee SG Mall harvest (6,353 listings, 79 brands) + iHerb SG K-Beauty harvest (2,738 clean SKUs, 170 brands, full INCI/rank/spec depth) · **Prices:** SGD

1 • Executive summary

The thesis: sell routines, not products. Both channels show the same shape — demand concentrates in serums, masks, cleansers and patches that Gen Z buys *in combination*, and the sellers winning right now are already selling combinations: bundle-titled listings hold **1 in 5 of Shopee's current Top-Sales slots** and carry a **+45% ticket** (S\$28.57 vs S\$19.74 median) over single units. A chain built on mix-and-match basket value — never single-SKU markdowns — is swimming with this current, not against it.

Six decisions this data supports:

1. **Open with ~250 SKUs across 25–30 brands**, weighted to the routine steps where velocity actually lives: serums/essences (the demand core, $\geq 98k$ units/30d on iHerb alone), moisturizers, masks & patches, cleansers.
2. **Anchor on the 44 brands validated on both channels** — COSRX, Anua, SKIN1004, Beauty of Joseon, Medicube, Biodance, TIRTIR, Some By Mi, VT, Mediheal, d'Alba lead the list. Dual-channel presence is the cheapest de-risking you can buy.
3. **Price the core wall at S\$15–30**. Median price is almost identical on both channels (S\$21.50 Shopee / S\$22.18 iHerb) — this band is where Gen Z K-beauty transacts. Reserve <S\$10 for the attach wall and >S\$40 for a small prestige capsule.
4. **Build the value engine as basket tiers, not discounts** — a Routine Builder (pick-3 / pick-5 across step zones), an attach wall of <S\$10 high-velocity items (patches, single-sheet masks, hand/foot masks), and cross-brand ingredient-story sets. Hero prices never move; value is only released when the basket deepens.

5. **Stock the baseline actives as the wall, merchandise the emergent ones as the story.** Hyaluronic acid, niacinamide and centella are table stakes (in 30–50% of all formulas). The heat is in **PDRN, glutathione, tranexamic acid and collagen-film formats** — fewer SKUs, much higher velocity per SKU.
6. **Move fast on a weekly signal loop.** The scrape infrastructure already tracks per-shop Top-Sales rank (refreshed harvests) and iHerb 30-day sold. Buy small, read weekly movers, kill/scale at 30–60–90 days.

2 • The evidence base

	SHOPEE SG (MALL / OFFICIAL STORES)	IHERB SG (K-BEAUTY FACET)
Listings / SKUs	6,353 (79 brands, 75 shops)	2,738 clean (170 brands)
Sales signal	Lifetime sold, bucketed lower bound (≥9.99M units total)	30-day sold rate, lower bound (≥372k units/mo across 841 SKUs showing it)
Current-demand signal	Per-shop Top Sales grid rank on 6,152 listings	Category best-seller rank on 94% of SKUs (58 SKUs hold a #1)
Depth	Title, price, rating, shelf, breadcrumb	Full INCI ingredients (99.2%) , GTIN, specs, price/ml, suggested use
Median price	S\$21.50 (p25 S\$14.18 / p75 S\$35.00)	S\$22.18 (p25 S\$16.28 / p75 S\$28.98)
Freshness	4 Aug 2026	11 Aug 2026

Read this before comparing channels. Shopee sold is *cumulative lifetime* (favours older listings); iHerb sold is a *30-day rate*. They must never be ratioed against each other — we use Shopee for "proven at scale" and iHerb for "moving right now", and a SKU that shows on both is the strongest buy signal there is. iHerb only displays sold above a floor (~31% of SKUs show it), so absence means *below the floor*, not zero. 193 iHerb rows whose product pages redirected to non-K-beauty items were detected and excluded from every number in this report.

3 • Market shape

3.1 Where the demand is (category × velocity)

iHerb 30-day units by routine step, with per-SKU velocity — the column that matters for shelf productivity:

ROUTINE STEP	SKUS	UNITS/30D (≥)	UNITS PER SKU	MEDIAN PRICE	READ
Essence / serum / ampoule	607	98,050	162	S\$26.10	The demand core. Deepest wall in the store.
Moisturizer / cream	451	65,150	144	S\$24.70	Core wall #2.
Sheet masks	208	34,050	164	S\$21.60	Splits: multipacks in core, singles (36 SKUs <S\$10) on attach.
Cleanser (foam/gel)	179	24,200	135	S\$19.80	Routine entry point; gateway SKUs live here.
Eye care	108	23,200	215	S\$20.90	Quietly outperforms — under-shopped, high velocity.
Pimple patches	33	20,300	615	S\$15.40	Highest velocity per SKU in the dataset. Small wall, huge traffic.
Makeup (colour)	230	18,500	80	S\$21.20	iHerb under-indexes here — see Shopee signal below.
Toner	168	18,300	109	S\$24.30	Core; toner <i>pads</i> (53 SKUs, S\$26.90 med) are the growth format.
Sunscreen	39	12,550	322	S\$25.30	Thin supply, strong velocity — stock deeper than the SKU count suggests.
Hair & scalp	101	10,550	104	S\$19.90	Real K-beauty adjacency (NARD, Kundal, Dr.FORHAIR).
Lip care / tint	278	8,450	30	S\$13.90	Oversupplied on iHerb; on Shopee lip works (Skintific lip serum ≥50k lifetime). Curate hard.

Mascara deserves a flag: 16 iHerb SKUs move ≥13,350/30d (834/SKU) — Heimish's Dailism mascara alone is ≥10,000/30d at #1. K-beauty colour in *cushion* + *mascara* + *tint* form is a real Gen Z lane even though iHerb's catalogue barely carries it.

3.2 Brand power (the two leaderboards)

Shopee lifetime units (proven at scale) · iHerb 30-day units (moving now)

#	SHOPEE BRAND	LIFETIME ≥	IHERB BRAND	30D ≥	#1 RANKS
1	cosrx	1,322,780	medicube	43,250	2
2	skintific	812,913	pyunkang-yul	32,400	1
3	torriden	705,779	vt-cosmetics	32,300	2
4	skin1004	650,652	aplb	29,750	4
5	medicube	559,469	cosrx	28,550	2
6	vt-cosmetics	398,207	beauty-of-joseon	23,850	3
7	some-by-mi	387,798	anua	19,650	2
8	nard (hair)	327,552	skin1004	19,650	2
9	grafen (hair)	282,165	heimish	17,650	2
10	tirtir	254,865	some-by-mi	17,150	3
11	beauty-of-joseon	248,482	dr-althea	13,200	3
12	dalba	231,830	petitfee	11,800	3

Names appearing high on **both** lists — COSRX, Medicube, VT, SKIN1004, Beauty of Joseon, Some By Mi, Anua (top-20 both sides) — are the anchor roster. Channel-exclusive stars are also signals: **Skintific and Torriden** are Shopee giants absent from iHerb (SEA-native distribution — negotiate direct), while **APLB** (112 SKUs, ≥29,750/30d, 4 category #1s) is an iHerb-native riser most SG retailers haven't shelved yet — a differentiation pick.

3.3 Price architecture

Both channels agree on the shape of the money:

- **<\$10 — traffic & attach** (12% of Shopee listings): patches, single masks, mists, hand/foot masks. This is impulse territory — the basket-builder zone.
- **\$10–30 — the transaction core** (56% of Shopee listings; iHerb p25–p75 sits entirely inside it): cleansers, toners, serums, creams, cushions.
- **\$30–50 — considered** (17%): premium serums, devices-adjacent, sets.

- **S\$50+ — prestige capsule** (14% of listings, mostly Laneige S\$52 med / Sulwhasoo S\$146): works at low depth; not the Gen Z engine.

4 • Trends

4.1 Ingredient demand — the wall vs. the story

Mined from the full INCI corpus (2,718 SKUs with ingredients × 30-day sold).

Baseline actives are ubiquitous — they're the wall, not a differentiator.

Emergent actives have fewer SKUs but much higher per-SKU heat — they're the endcap story that changes monthly.

INGREDIENT FAMILY	SKUS CARRYING IT	UNITS/30D (≥)	PER-SKU HEAT	STATUS
Hyaluronic acid	1,361 (50%)	228,850	168	Baseline — assumed, not advertised
Niacinamide	974 (36%)	177,900	183	Baseline
Centella / cica	866 (32%)	122,700	142	Baseline (barrier/calming wall)
Collagen	453	96,400	213	Rising — film/wrapping mask formats (Biodance, Medicube)
Ferments / probiotics	663	90,000	136	Steady (glass-skin narrative)
Ceramides	574	80,400	140	Steady (barrier)
Peptides	406	69,950	172	Rising (COSRX "6 Peptide Skin Booster" = skin-flooding trend)
Rice (oryza)	309	61,650	200	Rising (BOJ halo)
Mugwort / green tea / tea tree	~980	~176,000	140–210	Steady calming/oil-control wall
Glutathione	150	43,650	291	Hot — brightening story (APLB's whole line)
BHA (salicylic)	222	40,300	182	Steady (acne wall)
Heartleaf (houltuynia)	198	33,450	169	Steady-rising (Anua's identity)
Retinol / retinal	128	29,350	229	Rising (BOJ Ginseng+Retinal eye serum = #1 Eye Creams)

INGREDIENT FAMILY	SKUS CARRYING IT	UNITS/30D (≥)	PER-SKU HEAT	STATUS
PDRN / DNA	89	28,850	324	Hottest per SKU — Medicube PDRN Pink Peptide wave
Tranexamic acid	87	21,750	250	Hot (spot-brightening; Anua TXA serum)
Snail mucin	70	14,050	201	Icon status — small wall, COSRX essence ≥70k lifetime on Shopee

Merchandising translation: build permanent walls on *calming/barrier* (centella, heartleaf, ceramide, mugwort), *glow* (niacinamide, rice, vitamin C), *acne* (BHA, tea tree, patches). Rotate a monthly "what's new in Seoul" endcap through PDRN → glutathione → tranexamic → collagen-film → peptide-flooding. The heat column says these earn 1.5–2× the per-SKU velocity of the baselines.

4.2 Format trends Gen Z is actually buying

- **Collagen film / overnight wrapping masks** — Biodance Real Deep Mask: ≥90k lifetime, its bundle-of-2 is *currently* #1 in its shop grid; Medicube Night Wrapping Mask #1 K-Beauty Face Masks.
- **Toner pads** — Mediheal Daily Toner Pad ≥80k lifetime; Medicube Zero Pore Pad 2.0 #1 K-Beauty Toners. Jar formats built for the "prep + pack" ritual.
- **Cushions with shade-range depth** — TIRTIR Mask Fit Red (≥80k, #1 slot), Skintific cushions (≥90k). The Gen Z colour entry point.
- **Spray/mist serums** — d'Alba White Truffle First Spray Serum ≥70k and #1 in-shop.
- **Patches beyond acne** — microdart (Anua Triple Acid), eye hydrogel (Petitfee ≥3k/30d #1 Eye Masks), foot/hand masks (Petitfee foot pack S\$2.88, ≥3k/30d).
- **K-hair crossover** — NARD (≥328k lifetime, #1 shampoo slot), Kundal, Dr.FORHAIR, CP-1. A full aisle, not a token shelf.

5 • The assortment blueprint (~250 SKUs)

5.1 Shelf plan by routine step

ZONE	SKUS	PRICE BAND	ANCHOR EXAMPLES (ALL VERIFIED MOVERS)
Serums & ampoules	45	S\$20–33	Torriden DIVE-IN (≥90k), d'Alba spray serum (≥70k), Axis-Y Dark Spot (#1 Brightening), Medicube PDRN Pink, Anua TXA 4, COSRX 6-Peptide, SKIN1004 Centella Ampoule, BOJ Glow Serum (#1 Propolis)
Moisturizers & creams	30	S\$20–32	Dr. Althea 345 Relief (#1 Moisturizers, S\$40.58 — premium end), COSRX Snail 92 Cream, Anua Birch 70
Cleansers	25	S\$15–24	COSRX Low pH Good Morning (≥100k, current #1), Anua Heartleaf Quercetinol (#1 Cleansers), April Skin Carrotene (current #1), Heimish All Clean Balm
Masks & patches (attach + core)	35	S\$2.88–28	COSRX Pimple Patch (≥300k + #1), Biodance film mask, Medicube singles S\$3.50, SBM Clear Spot Patch, Petitfee eye/foot
Toners & pads	25	S\$18–30	Mediheal Toner Pad 2.0 (≥80k), Medicube Zero Pore Pad (#1), Anua Heartleaf 77
Sunscreen	15	S\$21–30	BOJ Relief Sun (≥80k), APLB Glutathione SPF50 (#1 Sunscreen), Skintific sun mist (≥70k)
Eye care	12	S\$16–26	BOJ Revive Eye Serum Ginseng+Retinal (≥10k/30d, #1), Petitfee Gold Hydrogel (#1), Axis-Y Vegan Collagen Eye (#1 Peptide)
Colour (cushion-led)	30	S\$12–30	TIRTIR Mask Fit Red, Skintific cushions, Heimish mascara (#1), 3CE, Judydoll, Missha brow (S\$8.35 attach)
Hair & scalp	15	S\$13–25	NARD shampoo, Kundal, Dr.FORHAIR Phyto Fresh (current #1), CP-1 treatments
Mist / body / foot	8	S\$3–18	Enough Collagen Mist S\$5.09 (#1 Face Mist), TonyMoly foot peel, Koelf hand/foot masks
Discovery & gift kits	10	S\$13–35	Idealove variety packs (#1 Gifts), brand starter kits (Celimax Noni kit = current #1 in-shop)

5.2 Brand roster in three tiers

- **Anchors (8–10, ~50% of units):** COSRX · Anua · SKIN1004 · Beauty of Joseon · Medicube · Some By Mi · VT · Biodance · TIRTIR · Mediheal. Every one is top-tier on at least one channel and present on both.
- **Support (10–12):** Torriden, Skintific, d'Alba, Heimish, Pyunkang Yul, Isntree, Dear Klairs, Axis-Y, Dr. Althea, Round Lab, Petitfee, plus hair anchors NARD/Kundal.
- **Emergent rotation (6–8, refreshed quarterly):** APLB (iHerb-native riser), Dr. Melaxin, Numbuzin, mixsoon (current #1 mover), Celimax, TFIT/fwee (colour), Abib. Small buys, fast reads.

6 • Basket architecture — the value engine

Design rule: the price tag never lies. No single SKU is ever marked down.

Value exists only as *basket depth* — the more steps of a routine you build, the better your rate. This protects hero-price integrity with every brand partner, trains members that value = combination, and directly lifts units per transaction.

6.1 Why the data says this works

- Bundle-titled listings are already **25.4% of the Shopee Mall assortment**, hold **19.7% of current top-3 Top-Sales slots**, and take **18.6% of all lifetime units** — at a **median ticket of S\$28.57 vs S\$19.74** for singles (+45%).
- The current #1 movers include *bundles as the hero itself*: Biodance "Bundle of 2 + Serum Duo SET" (#1), Torriden "Bundle of 2" (≥50k), COSRX "3/5/10 Packs" patches (≥80k), Some By Mi "3/5 Packs" spot patch (≥50k). Multi-buy isn't a promo layer on Shopee — it is the product.
- The attach math exists at scale: patches average **615 units/SKU/month** on iHerb (highest in the dataset) at S\$5–15; 36 sheet-mask SKUs sit under S\$10; Enough's S\$5.09 mist and Petitfee's S\$2.88 foot pack each move ≥3,000/30d.

6.2 The three mechanics

Attach Wall

<S\$10 · patches, single masks, mists, hand/foot masks

any 3 = S\$12 tier



Routine Builder

pick 3 / pick 5 across step zones, cross-brand

pick 3 ≈ 10% · pick 5 ≈ 18% value



Story Sets

curated cross-brand ingredient routines

named sets, seasonal rotation



Basket ≥ 3.5 items

heroes never discounted

1 • The Attach Wall (traffic → +1 item on every basket). A permanent fixture at register and queue: COSRX patches (S\$4.94), SBM spot patches (S\$5.13), Medicube single sheet masks (S\$3.50–3.74), Koelf hand/foot masks (S\$3.15–3.65), Enough mist (S\$5.09), Petitfee foot pack (S\$2.88), Nu-Pore strips (S\$2.88). Sold flat-price as "**any 3 for S\$12 / any 5 for S\$18**" — the tier is the only price event.

2 • The Routine Builder (the core engine). Every core-wall SKU carries a step tag (Cleanse / Tone / Treat / Moisturize / Protect / Eye). **Pick any 3 steps → bundle price ≈ 10% under the sum; pick 5 → ≈ 18% under.** Cross-brand by design — this is the mix-and-match promise, and it's what no brand's own store can offer. At median step prices (cleanser S\$19.80 + toner S\$24.30 + serum S\$26.10 + moisturizer S\$24.70 + SPF S\$25.30 = **S\$120.20 shelf**), the pick-5 lands at ~**S\$99** — a "complete routine under S\$100" flagship offer that discounts *nothing* individually.

3 • Story Sets (the rotation). Curated cross-brand routines named for the ingredient trend, refreshed with the endcap: *Heartleaf Reset* (Anua cleanser + toner + SBM patch), *Snail Repair* (COSRX essence + cream + Biodance mask), *Glass Skin Flooding* (Torriden serum + COSRX peptide booster + d'Alba mist),

PDRN Glow (Medicube serum + pink beauty mask + eye patch). Sets carry the pick-3 tier automatically and give TikTok-able names to what the ingredient heat table already shows selling.

6.3 Guardrails

- **Hero-halo integrity:** the ~25 hero SKUs (Appendix A) are never in any percentage event; they anchor tiers at full price. Value concentrates on the 2nd–5th items.
 - **Tier math over percent-off:** always express as bundle price ("routine for S\$99"), never "18% off" — percent language erodes reference prices; bundle language builds routine habit.
 - **Floor:** no tier should breach ~22% blended value release; the Shopee evidence shows bundles winning at a +45% *ticket*, not a giveaway margin.
 - **Member layer, not markdown layer:** if loyalty is added, deepen tiers for members (pick-5 at 20% equivalent) instead of cutting entry prices.
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7 • Speed playbook

Days 0–30 — buy the proven. Order the anchor roster from the 44 dual-channel brands; SKU-level pick list = the 58 iHerb category #1s + Shopee ≥50k-lifetime movers (Appendix A). Shallow depth (4–6 weeks cover), wide steps. Stand up the Attach Wall and pick-3 tier on day one — it needs no systems beyond POS bundle pricing.

Days 30–60 — read and rotate. The harvest loop already exists: weekly Shopee Top-Sales re-harvest surfaces each shop's current #1s (this week: mixsoon Bean Essence, April Skin Carrotene cleanser, Dr.FORHAIR shampoo, Celimax Noni kit — all new-wave, none yet ubiquitous in SG retail). Add the first emergent-brand buys (APLB, Numbuzin, mixsoon) at test depth. Launch Story Set #1.

Days 60–90 — kill and scale. Rules, not meetings: a SKU below ~50% of its step's median velocity for 6 weeks exits into the next Story Set (clearance-by-bundle, still no markdown); a SKU above 2× step median gets depth + a duo/twin pack (the Torriden/Biodance play). Rotate the endcap active. First seasonal gift kits (Petitfee/Koelf/Idealove pattern) before Q4.

Cadence thereafter: weekly movers read → monthly endcap rotation → quarterly roster review (emergent tier in/out). The `market_iherb_products` / `market_brand_*` tools serve all of this on demand, including full ingredient lists for shelf-talker copy and story-set curation.

8 • Risks & honest caveats

- 1. **Channel bias.** iHerb skews skincare (colour = 8% of its corpus); the colour/cushion thesis rests on Shopee evidence. Weight accordingly.
 - 2. **Sold figures are lower bounds.** Shopee buckets ("4k+ sold" → 4,000) favour tenured listings; iHerb hides sold below a display floor (31% coverage). Treat every unit figure as $\geq$, never exact; never compute cross-channel ratios.
 - 3. **SG-priced signals.** Ladder levels transfer as *structure*, not absolute numbers, to other markets.
 - 4. **Freshness window.** Shopee 4 Aug, iHerb 11 Aug 2026. Top-Sales rank is a weekly-moving signal — re-read before the opening buy is committed.
 - 5. **Excluded data.** 193 iHerb rows (6.6%) were redirect-contaminated (discontinued pages bouncing to unrelated products) and are excluded everywhere; the underlying discontinuations also hint those SKUs are exiting iHerb's range.
 - 6. **Coverage.** Shopee harvest covers 79 mall/official brands — the branded K-beauty universe, not all of Shopee. Grey-market resellers (often price-undercutters) are deliberately out of frame; monitor separately if price-matching policy matters.
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Appendix A • Hero SKU shortlist (opening buy anchors)

SKU	BRAND	EVIDENCE	PRICE
Acne Pimple Master Patch	COSRX	$\geq$ 300k lifetime · #1 iHerb Beauty Face Masks · $\geq$ 10k/30d	S\$3.91–4.94
Low pH Good Morning Cleanser	COSRX	$\geq$ 100k lifetime · current #1 in-shop	S\$4.95–22

SKU	BRAND	EVIDENCE	PRICE
Advanced Snail 96 Essence	COSRX	≥70k lifetime · #1 Snail Skin Care	S\$11.51–22.89
6-Peptide Skin Booster	COSRX	≥50k lifetime ("skin flooding")	S\$16.53
Bio-Collagen Real Deep Mask	Biodance	≥90k lifetime · duo currently #1 · #1 Collagen	S\$18.79–27.35
DIVE-IN Hyaluronic Serum	Torriden	≥90k lifetime · bundle ≥50k	S\$14.38
Mask Fit Red Cushion	TIRTIR	≥80k lifetime · #1 slot	S\$12.60
Daily Toner Pad 2.0	Mediheal	≥80k lifetime	S\$18.57
Relief Sun Rice + Probiotics	Beauty of Joseon	≥80k lifetime	S\$16.44
Revive Eye Serum Ginseng+Retinal	Beauty of Joseon	≥10k/30d · #1 Eye Creams	S\$23.00
Glow Serum Propolis+Niacinamide	Beauty of Joseon	≥4k/30d · #1 Propolis	S\$26.83
White Truffle First Spray Serum	d'Alba	≥70k lifetime · #1 slot	S\$12.10
Zero Pore Pad 2.0	Medicube	≥3k/30d · #1 K-Beauty Toners	S\$28.79
PDRN Pink Peptide Serum	Medicube	≥5k/30d · PDRN wave leader	S\$26.82
Beauty-mask singles (Collagen/PDRN/Zero Pore)	Medicube	≥2k/30d each · S\$1.99 Shopee collection ≥70k	S\$1.99–3.74
Heartleaf Quercetinol Cleansing Foam	Anua	≥4k/30d · #1 K-Beauty Cleansers	S\$17.31
Niacinamide 10 + TXA 4 Serum	Anua	≥3k/30d · tranexamic wave	S\$36.57
Madagascar Centella Ampoule	SKIN1004	≥3k/30d · #3 Centella · ≥650k brand lifetime	S\$21.86
Clear Spot Patch	Some By Mi	≥5k/30d · #1 slot · multipacks ≥50k lifetime	S\$5.13–7.77
Dailism Smudge Stop Mascara	Heimish	≥10k/30d · #1 Mascara	S\$15.50
Dark Spot Correcting Glow Serum	Axis-Y	≥4k/30d · #1 Brightening Serums	S\$26.51
Glutathione Niacinamide SPF50	APLB	≥7.5k/30d · #1 Sunscreen (differentiation pick)	S\$22.18
345 Relief Cream	Dr. Althea	≥5k/30d · #1 Moisturizers	S\$40.58
Gold Hydrogel Eye Patch (60)	Petitfee	≥3k/30d · #1 Eye Masks	S\$15.64
Shampoo (all hair types)	NARD	≥50k lifetime · #1 slot (hair aisle anchor)	S\$21.57

Appendix B • Reading the numbers

- **"≥" everywhere:** both platforms publish bucketed lower bounds ("4,000+ sold"). True figures are equal or higher.
- **Lifetime vs 30-day:** Shopee = units since listing began; iHerb = units in the trailing 30 days. Different clocks — used side by side, never divided.
- **#1 ranks:** iHerb = category best-seller rank scraped from each product page; Shopee "#1 slot" = first position on that shop's Top-Sales grid at harvest time.
- **Per-SKU heat:** $\text{units}/30\text{d} \div \text{SKUs carrying the trait}$ — the shelf-productivity proxy used for trend calls.
- **Source of truth:** all figures queryable live via the Fran MCP (`market_iherb_brands` , `market_iherb_products` , `market_brand_rollup` , `market_brand_compare`), including full INCI lists for any SKU above.